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5 AND 7 EAST 16TH STREET

and no sign of Jean was to be seen. With a sigh she once more entered the back room; she had scarcely, however, reached the threshold, when she paused and turned pale: a loud shout had echoed at the farthest end of the street.

"The conscripts!" exclaimed Antoinette, in a low tone.

"So soon!" replied Marie with seeming indifference; "don't you think it may be something else?"

"No, no," replied Antoinette in a feverish voice; "it is the conscripts; I hear their music."

The merry sounds of a harmonicon were heard at the end of the street as she spoke. Supported by Marie, and followed by her sister, the poor mother went to the door, nearly overcome by emotion. Mathieu prayed fervently in his bed.

When they looked out, the conscripts were still far down the street. Their hats were ornamented with tri-colored favors, and the number each had drawn, whether good or bad, was fixed in his hat-band, and visible even at a distance. But Antoinette and Marie vainly strove to distinguish Jean in the crowd.

"I see him!" at length cried Marie, turning pale.

"Ha! where is he? what is his number?" simultaneously exclaimed the two sisters, less clear-sighted than their young companion.

"There—there, beyond; he looked round this way; but I can see nothing of his number."

"Ay, ay, I see him now," eagerly cried Aunt Anne; "and, alas! poor boy, I can see his number too. Ah! I knew it—27!"

"It is not 27," hastily returned Marie; "for see, Aunt Anne, Jean holds up his hat to show it to us; the number begins with a one, and then there is a naught."

"Ah, 10," said Anne; "worse still than 27; I knew it was a bad one."

"No, it is not 10," continued Marie, in a tone tremulous with emotion; "there is another naught—it is 100." And falling down on a chair, she burst into tears, while Jean rushed into the shop, waving his hat in triumph.

Old Mathieu's joy, Antoinette's silent rapture, and Marie's bright smiles need not be described. Aunt Anne, though greatly delighted, was very much surprised; both her dreams and cards had for once failed signally. As for the dream, it was, she averred, quite her own mistake, for evidently the spot on Jean's forehead meant nothing; it should have been on his hat, to prove at all significant! Then she had most probably misdealt the cards; such an error could never otherwise have happened—nay, she even recollected something about a hundred! Further than this Aunt Anne would never yield when remonstrated with on this subject. It is, however, worthy of remark, that her faith in dreams and cards seemed rather shaken, as she thenceforth indulged in less speculation concerning them than formerly. As for the old neighbors, they were very much pleased, but not so much surprised; they were almost certain all would turn out well, but had not said so lest they should excite expectations that might be deceived.

The day was spent by the conscript and his family in much happiness; indeed, there was almost too much of this quality in it. The event was so delightful, so unexpected, so everything that was pleasant, that Antoinette, Anne, Marie, and Jean were bewildered. Mathieu seemed alone a little sensible. Toward evening they grew calmer, and after supper sat up to make plans for the future—the only apparent consequence of which was their separating very late. When Marie at length arose to depart, and bent over Mathieu to bid him good-night, she could not resist the temptation of whispering to him, "Well, Father Giraud, do you wish to die now?"

"No, Marie," said he, gazing on her affectionately; "no, not yet."

"And you, Mme. Giraud," playfully said the young girl, turning toward Antoinette; "don't you think we poor folks are sometimes as happy as the rich, if not a great deal more so?"

"Ay, and ten times as happy," warmly replied Antoinette, who was now quite merry.

"No, not ten times," smilingly observed Marie, "for, you know, God watches over both rich and poor."

In less than a year Jean and Marie were married, and old Mathieu, though still paralyzed, declared himself so happy at the event that he expressed his readiness to die;

which has not, however, prevented him from living ever since and repeating the same wish on the birth of his first grandchild, who, being a girl, will give her parents no uneasiness on the subject of the conscription. Jean and Marie have not grown very rich, but the shop has been newly painted, and, somehow or other, is oftener filled with customers than it used to be. It no longer contains any withered cabbages, and is so frequently visited by the children of the neighborhood that no fruit grows stale in it. Antoinette superintends the general concerns of the house, and Anne has taken charge of little Marie, whose horoscope she persists in formally drawing on every anniversary of her birthday. Jean attends to his work, and Marie, though she still contrives to earn a few francs with her waistcoats, attends to the shop, and, as old Mathieu declares, gladdens the whole place with her merry song. "And yet," as she often says, "how strange that all this happiness should have depended on one insignificant little number!"

THE ISLE OF SKULLS.

THE lonely wind-swept island of San Nicolas, eighty miles off the coast of Ventura County, California, is known as the "Isle of Skulls." A most peculiar name, but judging from recent reports of archæologists, who are now busy gathering the relics of a strange extinct race, this island is most appropriately called. San Nicolas and its erstwhile inhabitants have a history so curious that it is difficult of comprehension.

In 1835 the *padres* of Santa Barbara, learning that there were but sixteen persons left of the strange Indian race once living there, determined to rescue them from the island. They went over in a sloop, and succeeded, as they thought, in getting all on board. At the last moment an Indian woman returned for her child, and one of the frequent storms of the channel islands springing up, the sloop was driven away without her. The sloop went on the rocks of Point Conception, and all on board were lost.

Sixteen years later Capt. George Nidever and two men went from the coast on a sloop to hunt otter off San Nicolas. On landing they were, like Crusoe, astonished to discover human footprints in the sand. They saw no one, however, and a storm compelled them to put to sea.

It was two years thereafter that the adventurous captain, revolving in his mind the sight of the footprints in the uncanny island, determined to go and discover, and bring over the lonely woman of whom he had vaguely heard. Men accompanied him, and at length they saw on the surf-beaten shore a woman with long tawny hair dressed in a queer garb of colored bird-skins, and scraping, with a bone knife, the blubber from a seal. When suddenly surrounded and confronted she did not appear in the least afraid, but smiled, and then falling on her knees prayed to the sun. When by signs she was made to understand, and that she was to accompany her captors, she made no resistance.

They reached Santa Barbara across the rough sea, and the first thing the Indian woman saw was Dr. S. L. Shaw, now eighty years old and yet living there, riding a horse. She had never seen nor heard of any object like it, and thought the man and horse were one, and she knelt on the shore and offered her devotions to it. Two weeks afterward the last inhabitant of rock-ribbed, tempest-tossed San Nicolas died from eating food to which she was unaccustomed, furnished by her rescuers, and the curtain fell on her race forever. Had the woman rescued, then fifty-two years old, not died, a story passing strange would no doubt have been told of the race so long hemmed in by the waste of waters about. As it is, much of the story is shrouded in mystery forever. Her dress of red and blue feathers, a wonderful creation of barbaric hands, was sent to the Pope at Rome.

As far back as the memory of man runs, hundreds of white skeletons have dotted the valleys and hill-sides, and strange utensils of serpentine sandstone and steatite are constantly being found there among the human bones. Relic hunters have gathered mortars, pestles, ollas, toy steatite canoes, and other curious things there for some years past, and shipped them to various Eastern and European universities.

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